

UPDATING MY VIEWS ABOUT NETWAR

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Kat_the_Vat tells me it might help if I contribute some remarks to get your PLUR's purrs going at Prosocial Engineering's *Netwar Con: A Psyops Hackathon (The Last PsyOps)*, to be held in Austin, Texas, September 4-6, 2026. Here's what I would quickly offer in retrospect, and as prospect.

COMING UP AND WORKING WITH OUR NETWAR CONCEPT

In 1994, after our informal paper on *Cyberwar Is Coming* (1993) had circulated, John Arquilla and I found we had an invitation to propose a formal project on cyberwar or other aspects of information-age conflict. In wondering what to do, I told John I felt unsuited to working on hard-core military matters. Besides, our key hypothesis — the information revolution will favor network forms of organization and unsettle hierarchies — is going to have plenty of effects in non-military areas of conflict affecting national security, such as terrorism, crime, and militancy. Happily for me, John agreed. So I further said we should have a name for it — something to distinguish it from military cyberwar. Thus we started voicing potential catch-words; and to my admiration, John coined “netwar” — the keeper.

As I recall, this discussion lasted about 15 minutes, But it was enough to set in motion our series of RAND reports on *The Advent Of Netwar* (1996), *The Zapatista "Social Netwar" in Mexico* (1998), *Swarming and the Future of Conflict* (2000), and *Networks and Netwars: The Future of Terror, Crime, and Militancy* (2001), plus an independent paper on “Networks, netwars and the fight for the future” (2001),

Along the way, we also wrote *The Emergence of Noopolitik: Toward An American Information Strategy* (1999). It concerned the emergence of our planet's noosphere (“realm of the mind” and “thinking circuit” atop our planet's geosphere and biosphere, linking all people's thoughts). It didn't focused on netwar, but we still pointed out that

“Some of the best exemplars of the emergence of noopolitik involve ‘social netwar’ waged by civil-society activists,” for “nonmilitary netwar may prove the archetypal conflicts of noopolitik” (p. 47-48). Our examples included the Zapatista movement in Mexico (my favorite) and the International Campaign to Ban Landmines (John’s favorite).

RETHINKING SOCIAL NETWAR AS NOÖPOLITICAL NETWAR

Throughout the 1990s and into the 2020s, I’ve remained interested mainly in social netwar. Plenty of cases arose: notably the two just mentioned, plus the Battle of Seattle, Color Revolutions, Arab Spring, and Occupy! movements, not to mention slews of other cases (including MAGA?).

I’m still interested today. But since 2024 I’ve used “noöpolitical netwar” instead of “social netwar” as a descriptor, linking our ideas and observations about the noosphere’s emergence with those about the spread of netwar. This conceptual shift has made increasing sense, since so many social netwars are about gaining terrain in people’s “hearts and minds” across the noosphere — they’re about ideational noopolitics as much if not more than physical geopolitics (though the latter still matters as well).

KEY CONCERN: PEOPLE’S SPACE-TIME-ACTION COGNITIONS

There are many ways to identify what netwar is for — what it can be good at, what it aims to do. But I’m mostly only interested in and prepped to discuss one particular way, and that’s affecting people’s space-time-action cognitions (STAC), for better or worse. As I said in my first write-up about STAC in 2018, without mentioning netwar as a possible context,

“Imagine all kinds of people who have all kinds of beliefs. Next, imagine stripping away their high-level ideologies, values, norms, and everyday beliefs, until you

get down to their most basic notions that still amount to perceptive cognition about how the world around them looks and works. Stop there, before descending into a quivering mess of raw emotions, impulses, and instincts.

“What's there, I figured long ago, is an assemblage, a nexus, metaphorically a layer or module, in the mind that harbors people's basic orientations (assumptions, perspectives, perceptions, beliefs) about the nature of social space, time, and action. Briefly, by *space* I refer to how people see their identity positioned in relation to others, and how they perceive other subjects and objects, near and far — how they perceive all this as being structured, arrayed, linked. By *time*, I refer to how people discern, prioritize, and interrelate the past, present, and future, and what content they give to the past, present, and future. By *action*, I mean a sense of agency, of efficacy — whether and how people think they can act to affect matters around them. Thus, how people think and behave depends on the kinds of deep-down space-time-action cognitions they have.

“All three orientations — space, time, and action — are essential for the mind to work in ways that amount to social cognition and consciousness. A kind of “module” consisting of the three and their interactions takes shape during infancy and childhood. It's permanently there from then on. No mind can work without this cognitive triplex — most everything people think and do gets processed in and through it. It amounts to requisite cognitive knowledge, because space-time-action orientations lie behind much (all?) human awareness and deliberation.

Then, in a 2024 post about narrative hacking and story wars — noöpolitical netwar by another name — I contended that:

“All three cognitions — space, time, and agency — are essential for the mind to work in ways that amount to consciousness. A kind of module consisting of the three and their bundled interactions takes shape during infancy and childhood; and it's permanently there from then on. No mind can work without this cognitive

triplex — most everything people think and do gets processed in and through it. It amounts to requisite cognitive knowledge, largely determining how minds perceive, people act, cultures work, and even how historical eras and civilizations differ from each other (Ronfeldt, 2018).

“Narratives cannot be constructed, nor stories told, without reflecting and affecting people’s space-time-agency cognitions. Targeting them is so important in culture wars that narrative warfare is essentially cognitive warfare. Simply put, it makes a difference what perceptions people have about where they stand in relation to others (spatially), whether future trends look good or bad (temporally), and how much capability they feel they have to control matters around them (agentially). Weaponized narratives in particular seem designed to target people’s space-time-agency orientations, with three kinds of audience in mind: the proponents’ own adherents, their opponents, and audiences on the sidelines. Change people’s space-time-agency cognitions, and you change the game.

“For example, the significance of space-time-agency perceptions is fully on display among Trump’s admirers and supporters in economically depressed Rust Belt cities and Appalachian mining towns. Many people in these areas reportedly feel they have been “left behind,” disconnected from the rest of our country’s economy and society, with a diminished sense of pride, dignity, honor, and respect (spatially). Their future looks bleak, without much hope, and without it mattering what they accomplished for America in past eras (temporally). And there’s nothing they can do to fix their lot and change things for the better on their own (agentially). Trump’s “dreampolitik” is designed to attract people with forlorn mindsets and worldviews like theirs (Thompson, 2020; Hochschild, 2024; plus myriad other sources).” [Source: see fourth extra reading below.]

In other words, people have divided into what Peter Limberger and Conor Barnes aptly term “memetic tribes” (2025), thereby making America rife with noöpolitical netwars. People’s space-time-action orientations are the crux of what’s at stake, for better and for

worse. While all three orientations matter, I'd especially like you to notice this keen famous statement about time perceptions:

“Crossing frontiers is both man's heritage and man's task, and the image of the future is his propelling power. ... *The rise and fall of images of the future precedes or accompanies the rise and fall of cultures*. As long as a society's image is positive and flourishing, the flower of culture is in full bloom. Once the image begins to decay and lose its vitality, however, the culture does not long survive.” (Fred Polak, *The Image of the Future*, [1955] 1973, p. 5, 19)

Maybe narrative hackathon games like you are going to play can help find ways to address this.

AS FOR YOUR UPCOMING GAME

I've only now understood that the game you are set to play is fundamentally prosocial and poses quite a challenge for narrative strategy: Accordingly, you are various kinds of adventurers questing to build new homes for living together in a new land, Cyberia. In phase one of your two/three-day game, individuals must sort themselves into distinct small Tribes, with each Tribe articulating its own self-chosen identity. In phase two, the Tribes must find ways to cohere and organize into tribe-spanning Networks, again by focusing on identity matters. Across the course of the game, players must show they can integrate and uphold both their Tribal and Network identities.

Sounds like a truly forward-looking challenge to me — realistic and timely too, in light (and dark) of all that's going on in our society, culture, and politics. As I see matters, Tribes are about who to hug and hold close in kin-like ways — they're primarily an in-reaching form (kinda like Edmund Burke's "little platoons" and Alexis De Tocqueville's "voluntary associations"). In contrast, information-age Networks are about who to wave at and collaborate with from afar — they're primarily an outreach form. Healthy dynamic societies need both Tribes and Networks, and they need them to function well together

— like a noöpolitical axis, a backbone for the realm of civil society. I hadn't understood your game would be so strongly structured this way — now I'm delighted and eager to know more

As our planet's noosphere balloons in the years ahead, one of the grandest challenges will be develop networked planetary identities while still having meaningful localized tribal identities. I look forward to learning what you pro-social narrative hackers and creators come up with. I wish you well as noöpolitical-netwar warriors seeking to identify, mold, and articulate attractive possibilities for people's future identities, ideals, and visions — today for Cyberia, but tomorrow potentially for the world. Onward.

EXTRA READINGS

For a brief summary that still works well, try our “Networks, netwars and the fight for the future” (2001), online at:

<https://firstmonday.org/ojs/index.php/fm/article/view/889/798>

Also relevant but no longer easy to access is Robert Brose's “Cyberwar, Netwar, and the future of Cyberdefense” (2015), one online location being:

<https://ieeexplore.ieee.org/document/7158466>

Currently more relevant are posts by John Robb at his *Global Guerrillas* site, where he analyzes “networked insurgency” and “networked tribalism” yet covers much the same phenomena as netwar, at:

<https://johnrobb.substack.com>

If my space-time-action remarks interest you, take a look at “Dealing With Weaponized Narratives And Story-Wars: Part IV — A better way to attend to cognitive aspects of wargaming” (Oct 07, 2024), online at:

<https://davidronfeldt.substack.com/p/dealing-with-weaponized-narratives-561>

CODA: A LITTLE NIGHTCAP MUSIC

I see each hackathon tribe is supposed to come up with a song. Were I there, I might find something like King Tubby's "Tribal War" apropos, since he seems to sing "We don't want no more...":

King Tubby – Tribal War Dub – 2011

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5ujLpoukmfl>

Otherwise, I'll just enjoy it while sipping my evening whiskey nightcap.

Onward we go.